

Scenario-1

Scenario-1: Deadline for an Essay

Role A Student

Today is Thursday. You have two weeks to go before the end of your first term (semester). You're working on an essay which has to be handed in by 5 p.m. on Friday (tomorrow).

You are normally quite well-organised and you know that you have worked hard on this particular essay, but you have realised that you're not going to be able to finish it in time for tomorrow's deadline.

The main problem has been that you have been waiting for one specific book on your home country, to use in the essay. The only copy of the book in the University Library had been borrowed by another student. You asked for the book to be recalled, but it came back to the Library only yesterday. You need time to read and analyse the information in the book, and you think that will take you at least another two days. You reckon you should be able to finish the essay by Sunday.

You want to ask the tutor who set the essay to give you an extension of the deadline until Monday. Unfortunately, she is well-known for being very strict about deadlines. Earlier this term you were ill and the tutor agreed to give you an extension for another essay, but you think it's going to be difficult to persuade her this time.

What is the best way to ask for the deadline to be extended to Monday? What can you say if the tutor is unwilling to let you have an extension?

Scenario-1: Deadline for an Essay

Role B Tutor

The students on one of the courses you teach are working on an essay that you set them for tomorrow (Friday). The deadline by which they have to hand in their essays is 5 p.m.

One of the students has asked to see you and is probably going to ask for an extension of the deadline. Your department has no fixed policy about what to do when students miss deadlines. Your own rule is that if an essay comes in late without a good reason you take 10% off the final mark.

This particular student has already had one extension on an earlier essay, when he was ill. But he doesn't seem to be a very good student; he misses some lectures and comes in late to others.

This week you have a lot of work. Next week you are running a one-day conference for specialists in your field, so you plan to do all the marking (grading) of the students' essays this weekend. That will make it very difficult for you to accept a late essay unless there are exceptional reasons for doing so.

What will you say to the student if he asks you to extend his deadline? In what circumstances will you agree? What reasons will you give for not extending the deadline?

Scenario 4 DEADLINE FOR AN ESSAY

There are two sample performances of this scenario on side B of the cassette. The transcripts are shown on pages 212–220. One was recorded by two native speakers – a Scottish male as the Student and an English female as the Tutor. The other sample was recorded by two international postgraduate students at the University of Edinburgh – a Chinese female Tutor and a Portuguese male Student.

There are various ways of using the sample performances.

- You could play them to your class at the first Scenario session, before doing any of the scenarios, to show how the activity works.
- You could play them before or after the class has done Scenario 4.
- You could get the students to compare their performance with either the native or non-native sample.
- You could (also) get the students to listen to the two samples and compare the different tactics used by the speakers.
- We tend to use the sample performances as part of the Feedback stage, after discussing our students' own performances.

We've found that some EAP students prefer to listen to the non-native sample, because they think the native speaker version is too far beyond their capabilities, and represents an unachievable target. If the group feels that way, we use the international students' version.

Useful language

Student

Is there any chance of getting an extension for this essay?

I realise that it would be inconvenient, but...

I know I have already had an extension but...

I really did everything I could to get hold of the book but...

Tutor

This isn't the first time you've...

But it's a question of fairness.

I have to think about the other students.

You should have had plenty of time to...

Why didn't you come to tell me about this earlier?

A Model Conversation

Non-native Speakers

T = Tutor (female, Chinese)
S = Student (male, Portuguese)

S hi Dr Wu

T good morning

S good morning / uh I came to see you because I have a little problem with uh tomorrow's deadline

T uhuh

S for the essay uh the question is...since the beginning since I started preparing the assignment the essay I...I always wanted to put some data from my own country to...to turn the essay richer and be more interesting for me as well but there's a problem that the book I needed to to to search...to get information from is...was borrowed and there's only one copy in the library / so it was borrowed a long time ago / I recalled it and uh I could only have access to the book uh...yesterday so as the deadline for the essay...the essay is tomorrow I think it will be impossible for me to to read the book and analyse it and write uh the essay for tomorrow / my guess is that I will need at least two more days um to do that and probably I will only be able to hand in the assignment on Monday

T how much have you finished?

S um basically...I only need to put that data / apart from that everything is almost done so...it's only that part

T hm could you write it more...

...on Monday

T how much have you finished?

S um basically...I only need to put that data / apart from that everything is almost done so...it's only that part

T hm could you write it more...more quickly? because I'm very busy next week I have no time to mark the essay I think / I want to mark the essay in this weekend / I think it's good to mark all the students' essays together / uh it's fair to other students / if I can't do this work this weekend um the other students can't get their essay back

S hm yes I understand I understand but...I reckon that I think it will be only possible for me to to to finish the essay on Sunday um...uh maybe I don't know but um...you could mark the whole papers on on the weekend and uh...then you will only have mine to mark

T yeah

S on Monday

T no I couldn't mark it on Monday / I have a I have a meet...I have a meeting at that day

S uhuh

T so I think it's better if you hand in your homework before the Sunday

S uhuh

T so I can have some times to mark it

S hmhm

T is it possible?

S um it might be but I think it will be um...um there will be a very low probability because...I need to read the book and I start...I have already started but uh the book is not so simple and um...I think at least I will need to...I will need two more days / Sunday

T you

S Saturday and...

T we have to...

S and finish it on Sunday I could hand / I don't know but

T you see today is Thursday you can read it today tomorrow and you can write it at Saturday yeah? it's ok?

S um maybe yes I think...uhuh maybe...I'll have to work really hard to do that for Sunday...for Saturday yes Saturday

T yes

S you think uh...I only I can only hand in the assignment on Saturday?

T yeah

S it's not possible on Sunday or Monday?

T I think it's not possible

S uh...all right I'll...do my best I'll try to to hand it...

T ok

S hand in on Saturday / will you be around in the university?

T yes I will be in my office at Saturday afternoon so you can hand it to my office

S hmhm all right hmhm I'll try / thank you very much

Scenario-2

Language Centre

Scenario 2 Language Centre

Role A: Student

It is the week before the start of the academic year. Earlier this week you took the English matriculation test for international students, and scored as follows.*

Listening	61%
Reading	68%
Writing	63%
Average	64%

According to the results letter from the Language Centre, your average score is slightly above IELTS 6.5 and you are not required to take any additional English classes. When you took IELTS for your application to the university, you scored 6.0, which was the minimum acceptable score.

However, since arriving at the university, you have realised that most of the other students on your degree course are native speakers of English, and you feel you will be at a disadvantage because of your language level. Your scores seem rather low to you; you are used to getting 80% or more on the English courses in your home country.

The Language Centre runs first-term evening courses in listening, reading and writing. You applied to take all three, but you have had a letter from the course director saying the courses were only open to people with lower scores than you. You have made an appointment to speak to the course director, to see if he will allow you onto the courses. What reasons can you give him for needing to take further tuition?

Scenario-2: Language Centre

Role B: Language Course Director

You are responsible for the English courses provided to help international students taking degree courses at your university. All international students have to take an English language test (with sections on Listening, Reading and Writing) at the start of the academic year. If they score below 60% overall, or if they have a section score of less than 60%, they are required to take the relevant evening courses, which start in week 3 of the first term. Those courses focus on the skills of listening, reading, and writing.

There are always more students than places, so you limit entry into the classes by giving higher priority to the students who have less than satisfactory scores on the matriculation test. In your experience, many of the students who apply to do the courses do not really need further tuition. As a general rule, you do not accept anyone onto the courses who has scored more than 60% on the relevant section of the test. Your policy is to put higher-scoring students on a waiting list for each class. If there are still spare places when the classes start in week 3, you give those places to the students on the waiting list, strictly in order of score (someone with a score of 61% gets higher priority than someone with 67%).

You can make exceptions. For example, if you get a report from a student's department that they are having problems with English, you sometimes accept them with a score of over 60%.

A student has made an appointment to see you. She applied for all three courses, but has scored too high to be accepted automatically. She probably wants you to change your mind, but this year there is greater demand for courses than ever before. How will you deal with her request? What alternative can you offer her?

Useful Expressions

Student

I'm sorry to bother you, but I wanted to ask about...

I'm a bit worried about...

Everyone else on my course is a native speaker, so...

I really don't feel that my... is good enough.

After all I only got just over 60.

Why can't I have a place?

Language course director

The problem is that...

Have you any reason to think you have serious language problems?

Instead of coming to classes, why not...?

I think you should...

We have to give priority to...

Scenario-3: Library

Role A Student

It is the last week of the vacation before the start of the academic year, when your academic course begins. Last week you completed a pre-session language course and this week you want to spend working on the preliminary reading list of books that you have been sent for your degree course. According to the instructions from your department, students are expected to have read the main items on the list before term (semester) starts.

Although some of the books are available in the bookshops, they are very expensive. You have been told that there are copies of all of them in the departmental library. The problem is that this week the library is only open in the afternoon, and one of the other students has told you that the librarian has decided not to lend books this week.

You have decided to go to the library and see whether the librarian will allow you to borrow books. Can you think of good reasons that might persuade her to lend you the books you need? Can you think of alternatives for if she refuses to let you have all the books?

Scenario-3: Library

Role B: Librarian

You are the head librarian of a departmental library. It is Monday afternoon of the last week of the summer vacation and you are preparing for the beginning of the academic year next week by doing your annual stocktaking. Normally, you would have the help of the assistant librarian but she is away on holiday. So you are doing the stocktaking on your own. Because of this you have decided to keep the library closed in the mornings this week, so as to allow you to work uninterrupted. So for this week only, the opening hours are 2–5 p.m., Monday to Friday.

There are very few students around at the moment, so you have decided not to lend books this week. Any students that come in asking to borrow items from the library can be told to wait until term starts. Alternatively, they can use the main university library, which is open at its normal times – 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. on weekdays.

A foreign student comes in and asks about borrowing books from the library. How can you make it clear to him that you are not allowing any borrowing this week? Is there some alternative you can offer?

Useful Expressions

With this scenario, it's a good idea to check that the students who are preparing the Librarian role realise that it was *their* decision to restrict the opening hours and not to allow students to borrow books, and not a general university rule. That gives the Librarians the option – though they are not always willing to use it – of making an exception for the Student and allowing him to borrow, assuming that it doesn't lead to many more 'me-toos' making the same request.

Here are some of the expressions we have elicited from students or provided ourselves.

Student

I was wondering whether I could...

Can I explain my problem?

I can see you're busy but...

I'm afraid that would be too late for me to...

Is there a rule that says I can't borrow?

Librarian

I appreciate your problem, but...

If I make one exception, then I will have to...

Couldn't you...?

How about...?

Well, perhaps I can lend you one book overnight.

Scenario-4: Finding Accommodation

Role A: Student

The university term (semester) has already started and you still don't have permanent accommodation. You are staying in a guest house, which you are finding very expensive. You need to find accommodation urgently because your family is coming to join you in a month's time.

What you want is a flat (apartment) with the following features:

- two bedrooms and plenty of space
- a maximum rent of per month
- near your university department, to save you travel time and money.

There are two ways of finding a flat. One way is to go through the University Accommodation Service; the other is to look for a private flat, but that tends to be more expensive.

You have already been twice to the Accommodation Service. The same man dealt with you both times. He offered two different flats, but neither of them was suitable. You feel that the man is beginning to lose patience with you. However, you have made another appointment to see him because one of the students doing your course has told you there are some unoccupied university flats near your department. You don't know why the Accommodation Officer has not mentioned them to you.

Plan what to say at your new appointment, to find out more about these unoccupied flats. Think of ways of persuading the Accommodation Officer to let you see one of them.

Scenario-4: Finding Accommodation

Role B: Accommodation Officer

You work in the Accommodation Service office of the University. It's the first week of the term (semester) and you are extremely busy. An international student came to see you a couple of weeks ago looking for a two-bedroom flat (apartment). You offered her a flat that you thought was exactly what she wanted, but she didn't like it. You offered her another one, and she didn't like that one, either. She seems to be quite difficult to please.

The student has made another appointment to see you today. Usually, the Accommodation Service tries to give priority to international students, because they are often unable to arrange accommodation in advance. Now that the term has started, it is getting really difficult to find flats of the type the student wants.

There is in fact a block of two-bedroom university flats very close to the student's department, but at the moment the flats are being modernised and redecorated. The work will probably not be finished for three or four weeks, so you didn't mention them to the student when she came in before. When the flats are ready, the rent will be per month, excluding service charges (heating, lighting and telephone).

You have one large two-bedroom flat which you think will suit the student. It's about 10 minutes by bus from her department. The rent is a month, including all charges (except the telephone). You have decided that if she doesn't accept this flat, you are going to recommend her to look for private accommodation.

Discuss how you can give her that advice without appearing to be unhelpful. After all, it's your job to find students the accommodation they need.

Useful Expression

Scenario 3 FINDING ACCOMMODATION

The blank rent 'boxes' in the role materials should be completed with whatever you and the class think is a realistic rent in the appropriate currency.

For the task dynamics to work best, the figure in the Student's information should be roughly midway between the two rents in the Accommodation Officer's information. For example, current figures suitable for Edinburgh would be £500 for the Student's budget, and £480 and £530 respectively for the two blank boxes in the Accommodation Officer's information. This means that the Students have to weigh up the advantages of the two flats – one available now with the higher but inclusive rent, against the cheaper one that will mean several weeks' wait.

Useful language

Student

I hope I'm not being a nuisance...

I really do need to find a flat nearer to...

*How soon would I be able to move in?
That's more than I can afford.*

Accommodation officer

*Well, you have to realise that...
I'm afraid there's not really very much more I can do for you.
I could give you a list of agencies.*

Scenario-5: Examination Results

Role A: Student

It is the beginning of the second term (semester) of your university course. At the end of last term your class did a 'mock' exam and you didn't do very well. In fact you hadn't really expected to do well, because most of the course topics were new to you. But the topics for the second term are more familiar so you expect to do better on them.

You feel determined to work harder this term, too. That may mean you have to concentrate on your studies and avoid the various distractions, such as the sports and social activities that took up some of your time in Term 1.

The Director of Studies for the course has asked you to come and see him to discuss your exam results. If your marks weren't very good, what reasons can you give to explain them and to show that you expect to do better now?

Scenario-5: Examination Results

Role B: Director of Studies

It's the first week of the second term (semester) of the university year. The students you are responsible for took a 'mock' exam at the end of last term. You have arranged a meeting with each student to give them their results.

One of the international students on the course is causing you and the other lecturers special concern. The questions she asks in your lectures suggest that she misunderstands quite basic points. It is not clear whether this is due to her poor English or to her lack of background knowledge. She contributes very little to tutorial discussions and her only piece of written work – apart from the mock exam paper – was very disorganised and hard to follow.

In the mock exam most of this student's answers were off the point; her overall result was a Fail. You and your colleagues have discussed her case at a course meeting and the general view is that she is at risk of failing the course. In the light of her apparent language problems, it was decided at the meeting that she should be required to attend an evening English course this term.

The student is on her way to your room to get her exam result. You need to think carefully how best to make clear to her the seriousness of her situation, because her listening is relatively weak.

Scenario 5 EXAMINATION RESULTS

Useful language

Student

I had a feeling it wouldn't be very good.

I think there are probably a number of reasons why I didn't do very well.

I've probably spent too much time on...

I realise I'm going to have to...

Director of Studies

I'm afraid your result wasn't too good.

You seem to be having some problems with...

To be honest, we're worried about your work.

There's a real risk that you...

We feel that you should go to the English language classes.

Scenario-6: Changing Accommodation

Role A: Student

You are staying in a hall of residence (dormitory) run by your university. There are two problems with your room. The first is that the building is quite old – from the 1960s – and so your room is cold, even when the heating is on. You can't really study there comfortably and you have to use the university library, which is 20 minutes' walk away.

The second problem is that the students who live in the rooms around yours are a lot younger than you and make a lot of noise at night, so you can't concentrate when you need to work in your room.

You've tried complaining to the Accommodation Manager about the cold and the noise. She suggested you should put on another layer of clothes when you feel cold and ask the students to be quieter when their noise disturbs you.

University accommodation is relatively expensive in the city and you have had to pay for your room in advance. You think the university may operate this system of payment in advance to discourage students from moving. The rental contract you signed was for a minimum of six months and you had to sign it before seeing the rooms, which you feel was unfair.

Because of these problems, you've decided to speak to the Accommodation Manager to see if you can move to a different hall of residence, where the students are a bit older and quieter and where the rooms are warmer. What can you tell her to persuade her to let you change accommodation?

Scenario-6: Changing Accommodation

Role B: Accommodation Manager

It's halfway through the first term (semester) of the university year. One of the international students staying in the hall of residence (dormitory) that you manage has made an appointment to see you. He is a mature student, in his forties, and seems to be finding it hard to study again. He has complained in the last month that his room is cold and noisy. He tends to wear quite thin clothes and you advised him to get some jumpers to help him feel warmer. You can't really do much about the noise, which comes from the younger students living in rooms nearby.

You think this student may want to move to another room or possibly to a different university residence. At the moment you have no other rooms available. It's possible that a room may be vacated at the end of the term, because one or two students move out. For example, there is one PhD student who should be going home then, if she passes her oral exam.

Think about how best to deal with the student's complaints. Plan what strategy to use if he asks you to allow him to move.

Scenario 6 CHANGING ACCOMMODATION

Useful language

Student

I can't stay in the room.

It's having a bad effect on my work.

I need a quieter place to study.

Isn't there another room available?

Can I move to a different residence?

Accommodation Manager

I do sympathise but...

There's nothing available at the moment.

You might be able to move in the vacation.

That's not really my responsibility.